

ANI

SUCCESSION STORY?
CM Nitish with his deputy and RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav

speculation about wannabe CMs. So, while the BJP leaders have different favourites, including Union MoS for home Nityanand Rai, the RJD seems just as obsessed with the possibility of Tejashwi taking over the post. As Nitish has openly spoken about letting the young RJD chief lead the grand alliance in the 2025 assembly election, the RJD is quite excited at the prospect of having a CM-in-waiting in their camp.

In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, the NDA had won 39 of Bihar's 40 seats, with the JD(U)'s share being 16 of those seats. The RJD, Nitish's current partner, had drawn a blank back then. In 2024, Nitish will have much more to worry about than just the BJP juggernaut. If, as the Nitish camp believes, the BJP was always planning to replace him with one of their own after the Lok Sabha election (a big reason for his snapping ties in August 2022), there's also the threat of Tejashwi's RJD stealing a march over the JD(U) in the election. The 2024 election will then, in a sense, be a battle for his own and his legacy's survival. A solid JD(U) performance, on the other hand, will reinforce the perception of Nitish as Bihar's undisputed leader and enable him to dictate terms not just in the state but also, perhaps, even in New Delhi. A poor show will have both opponents and alliance partners snapping at his heels.

Nitish is acutely aware that the success of the MGB alliance will depend a lot on how supporters of the various partners respond to their joint anti-BJP appeal. The RJD commands the formidable M-Y (16 per cent Muslim and 14 per cent Yadav) axis whereas the JD(U) has a similar cohort of EBCs and Mahadalits rallying behind Nitish.

While Nitish has responded with an "*Ekdum karega* (Absolutely, he will)" to questions about whether he will let Tejashwi lead the MGB in the next assembly election, some camp followers see this as part of a strategy to first integrate the voters of the two parties in the run-up to the Lok Sabha polls. The promise has also silenced the most ambitious among the RJD leaders, who had been pushing for Tejashwi in Bihar.

Though Nitish is unlikely to stake a claim to the prime minister's post in the event of an opposition victory in 2024, an exceptional JD(U) performance could, as a close aide put it, "open the floodgates of opportunities". Bihar's 40 LS seats, the fourth largest among states, could be crucial in a close election. Nitish, however, is on the record saying he would accept the Congress's Rahul Gandhi as a possible leader of the opposition alliance. That said, the fact that he did not join Rahul for the Bharat Jodo Yatra despite the Congress being an MGB member, does send conflicting signals.

Meanwhile, Tejashwi too is biding his time. The RJD chief accompanied Nitish to Saran and Vaishali during the Samadhan Yatra and insists that the focus is not on the CM's chair but the 2024 general election.

The combined political capital of Nitish and Tejashwi has undoubtedly made the challenge enormous for the BJP in Bihar. But the MGB does not have it easy either. In the three bypolls since November 2022, the alliance lost two seats, including Kurhani in Muzaffarpur district, which it held. Analysts attribute it to the social base of MGB constituents fragmenting at the ground level. There is a perception that the committed vote banks of RJD and JD(U) are not on the same page.

The yatra, then, was also to reinforce these votebanks. If Nitish is to neutralise the saffron challenge effectively, the feedback JD(U) says it has received will be crucial in fine-tuning a political response for 2024. ■

WOMEN HOLD UP THE CENTRE

One of the highlights of the Samadhan Yatra was the interactions with the Jeevika didis wherever Nitish went. Jeevika is an 11.7 million-strong women community active in the state, empowering poor rural households by providing women easy and hassle-free access to credit through banks. This has made them financially self-reliant, a massive change in unabashedly patriarchal Bihar. Nitish has made women a key constituency, reserving 50 per cent seats in panchayats and 35 per cent in government jobs, and providing free clothes, books and cycles for schoolgoing girls (which created a huge jump in school enrolment and reaped political dividends). Again, in 2016 when Nitish agreed to prohibition, it was in accordance with their demands. The impact of all this is reflected at the hustings. The 2020 assembly poll was the third election in a row where the proportion of women voters was more than their male counterparts. A higher female voter turnout is said to be to Nitish's advantage.